

Wildcat

Felis silvestris

thick coat with
distinct dark stripes



At first glance, any of the 19 subspecies of wildcat could be mistaken for a domestic tabby—not surprisingly, as the African subspecies, *F. s. lybica*, is its ancestor. Look closely and differences emerge. European wildcats, for example, are generally larger than domestic cats, with longer, thicker coats, broader heads, and flatter faces. Their dark-ringed tails are also shorter, with blunt, black-tipped ends. In Europe, wildcats inhabit mainly mixed forests or broadleaved woods, but in other parts of the world, their habitats range from desert to alpine meadows.

Passing on hunting skills

Wildcats have excellent night vision and mainly hunt small mammals, although some subspecies occasionally hunt young deer. They are solitary and highly territorial, except when mating and rearing kittens—two to five is the usual litter size. As weaning begins, the mother brings live food to the den, often an old rabbit burrow or fox den, to teach the kittens to hunt. They become independent at five to six months. Hybridization is considered the main threat to this species as domestic cats readily breed with wildcats.

▷ STAY AWAY

Wildcats use urine and feces to mark their territories, but also communicate vocally, yowling and snarling to warn off intruders.

- ↔ 16–30 in (40–75 cm)
- ⚖ 5–16 lb (2–7.25 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐭 Rodents, birds, reptiles
- 🏠



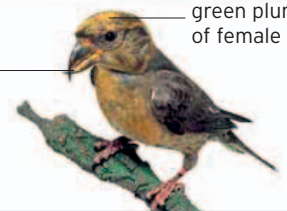
Europe, W. and C. Asia, Africa



Scottish crossbill

Loxia scotica

crossed
bill tips



The Scottish crossbill is the only bird endemic to Scotland. A member of the finch family, it lives in the Scots pine forests of the Highlands, where it feeds almost exclusively on ripe cones, using its specialist bill to pry apart the scales so it can reach the seeds with its tongue.

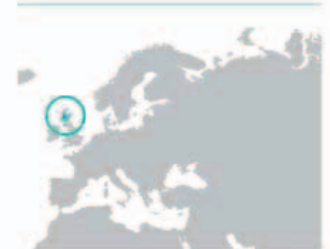
Courtship begins in late winter or early spring, with flocks of males competing to see who can sing the loudest. Once a female selects a male, he touches his bill to hers, then feeds her. They build a nest of twigs high up in a pine tree and two to six eggs are laid, usually in March or April. Incubation lasts around two weeks, the male feeding the female all this time, and then both birds feed the chicks. They leave the nest after three weeks, but the parents have to feed them for 10 more days—until their bills are crossed.

Tough call

Two other species of crossbill also breed in the UK: the common crossbill, which feeds on spruce cones, and the slightly larger parrot crossbill, which specializes in tough pine seeds. Telling them apart is difficult, but they can be distinguished by their distinct calls.



- ↔ 6–7 in (16–17 cm)
- ⚖ 1–2 oz (36.5–49 g)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🌲 Conifer seeds, buds
- 🏠



NW. Europe (UK)

◁ SCOTTISH MALE

The male is red like the common and parrot crossbill males, but its muscular neck and large bill are intermediate between those two species.